forces. The Chinese, therefore, opened 'negotiations' with the Tibetan government. In May 1951, they signed the 17-Point Agreement that nominally gave Tibet an autonomous status, although the opening sentence was explicit in stating that Tibet lay within the boundaries of China.

The Tibetan government was reduced to being a local government. The Chinese saw the 17-Point Agreement as only a partial achievement of their objective of legitimizing their control over Tibet, since they recognized that the unique institution of the Dalai Lama meant they needed his consent. During the Sino-Tibetan negotiations, a constant Chinese concern was the possibility of flight by the Dalai Lama to India. The Chinese leadership, therefore, continued to keep India on its side. Despite the mutual bitterness and recrimination over the PLA's invasion at the end of 1950, Mao Zedong himself was the chief guest at India's first Republic Day celebration in January 1951. He was very cordial and made no reference to the unpleasantness between the two sides over Tibet. In March, Premier Zhou Enlai similarly engaged Ambassador Panikkar on the issue, taking him into confidence on the state of negotiations with Tibetan authorities and even suggesting that this was in conformity with India's advice. Zhou's real objective was to ensure that the Dalai Lama did not flee to India. He told Panikkar that some people were urging the Dalai Lama to leave for India, and that China wished the Dalai Lama to remain in Tibet so that the negotiations were settled in a mutually acceptable way. Zhou said that India's interests were that peace of her frontiers should not be disturbed, leading to unsettled conditions, and he hoped that the Government of India would not encourage the Dalai Lama to leave the country, or else it would bring a 'dark cloud between our good relations of friendship'. As a final sop, he gave another assurance to Panikkar that all Indian interests in Tibet could be safeguarded